

26th Annual Carolina Cup

October 2–4, 2026 • Columbia & Irmo, South Carolina

Welcome to our Carolina Cup guide. We put this together so everything about the weekend — travel, lodging, the venue, and what we're still waiting on from the tournament — lives in one place instead of scattered across emails and the group chat. As the tournament releases more information, we'll send updated versions of this same guide.

At a Glance

The one-minute version. If you read nothing else, read this.

Where	Complex not yet assigned Five SCUFC complexes • Columbia / Irmo, SC
When	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026
Bracket	Under 09 Boys Red Division
Drive	~169 miles • ~3h 15min from Savannah
Hotel	Country Inn & Suites at Harbison — \$161/night Harbison cluster • cheapest confirmed
Do today	Book the hotel — hold a free-cancellation rate while you decide
Waiting on	Game schedule & field assignments (Sep 24)

1. Tournament Quick Start

Everything a busy parent needs, in under a minute.

Event	26th Annual Carolina Cup
Host	South Carolina United FC (SCUFC)
Team	Savannah United 17/18B Premier
Dates	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026

Venue	Complex not yet assigned Five SCUFC complexes · Columbia / Irmo, SC
Age Group	U9 · 7v7 format
Bracket	Under 09 Boys Red Division
Format	Group play → knockout rounds
Entry Fee	\$725 per team for U8–U10 (7v7)
Check-in	Online check-in only. There is no on-site check-in.
Stay-to-Play	Not published — see Section 6
Drive	~169 miles · ~3h 15min via US-17 N → I-95 N → I-26 W
Parking	Free on-site at SCUFC complexes

2. Parent Action Items

DO THIS NOW

☐ Book your hotel

Re-checked live on September 18, 2026. Our top pick is now the Country Inn & Suites at Harbison at **\$161 per night**; the Hampton Inn Harbison did not come back as available and we have withdrawn it. See Section 6 for the full list.

ACTION REQUIRED

☐ Complete online check-in

The accepted team list posted on September 14 and Savannah United 17/18B Premier is confirmed on it. SCUFC states that online check-in is open and that teams should start it **immediately**. There is **no on-site check-in** at this event, so this cannot be handled at the field. Re-verified September 18, 2026.

BRACKET POSTED — SEPTEMBER 16

☐ Know who is in your bracket

Our division is **Under 09 Boys Red Division**. Section 3 lists every team we could meet. The game-by-game schedule — pairings, kickoff times and fields — posts September 26; we'll send the updated guide with calculated departure times for each family.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

☐ Pack using the checklist

Section 12 has the full list. The live outlook puts the Midlands near 87°F Friday and 84°F Saturday with a chance of showers; the ten-year pattern swings from about 63°F in the morning to around 80°F in the afternoon — bring layers as well as heat gear.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

☐ Review the tournament rules

SCUFC has not published the 2026 rules document yet. Section 13 explains what we know and what we're still waiting on.

3. What We Know & What We're Waiting For

Confirmed

Official Tournament Information: 26th Annual Carolina Cup, October 2–4, 2026, hosted by South Carolina United FC in the Columbia/Irmo area of South Carolina.

Official Tournament Information: Open to boys and girls teams, U8 through U19, at Recreational, Intermediate, and Advanced levels. U8–U10 play 7v7.

Official Tournament Information: All teams must complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in.

Official Tournament Information: Tournament director is Tripp Miller (tripp@scufc.com). SCUFC phone: 877-457-2832.

Confirmed Team Information: Savannah United 17/18B Premier is accepted and scheduled to attend.

Pending Confirmation

Confirmed: Savannah United 17/18B Premier is on the official accepted team list (09U Boys). Online check-in is required — there is no on-site check-in.

Confirmed: our bracket is **Under 09 Boys Red Division** — 5 teams in total. Opponents in our division:

- CESA U9B Pre ECNL-RL Summit 1
- FC Revival U9 Boys Navy
- JIYSC U9 Boys Red Chambers
- SCUFC U9 Boys Blue

Verified at the source on the tournament site. The game-by-game pairings, kickoff times and fields are published with the full schedule on September 26, 2026.

Confirmed now: The game schedule, opponents and field assignments are published and listed above.

Pending Confirmation: Whether a stay-to-play housing requirement applies. No policy has been published.

Pending Confirmation: The 2026 tournament rules document, including game length, mercy rule and tiebreakers.

Pending Confirmation: Coach instructions on uniform and any last team-specific details.

4. Tournament Overview

The Carolina Cup is run by South Carolina United FC and is now in its 26th year. It draws teams from across the Southeast to five complexes across

the Columbia and Irmo area, and it has been one of the region's larger youth soccer weekends for a long time. Our U9 team will play 7v7.

Official Tournament Page (SincSports):

soccer.sincsports.com — Carolina Cup

Host Club:

southcarolinaunitedfc.com

Official Rules Document:

Not yet published for 2026

5. Travel & Arrival Planning

Drive from Savannah

Route: US-17 North → I-95 North (about 80 miles) → I-26 West (about 67 miles) → US-76 into Irmo.

Total: ~169 miles. Routing re-verified September 18, 2026 (168.9 mi / 3h 12min, free-flow).

Scenario	Time	Notes
Free-flow driving	~3h 15min	Routing engine, no stops
With a fuel and rest stop	~3h 35min	Add ~20 min
Friday evening traffic	~4h 00min	Add ~45 min

Why the first number is the real one: the free-flow figure of ~3h 15min is the routing calculation for the most direct route with no stops. The 3h 35min and 4h 00min figures are our own additions for a rest stop and for Friday evening traffic — they are planning buffers, not separate route measurements.

Player Report Time

Game	Kickoff	Arrive	Depart Savannah
Saturday, October 3 vs CESA U9B Pre ECNL-RL Summit 1 Field 2A	10:30 AM EDT	9:45 AM	6:30 AM
Saturday, October 3 vs CFA 17/18 Red Field 2B	3:30 PM EDT	2:45 PM	11:30 AM
Sunday, October 4 vs SCUFC U9 Boys Blue Field 2B	10:30 AM EDT	9:45 AM	6:30 AM

Arrival is 45 minutes before kickoff. Departure is calculated from Savannah using the verified drive time of about 3h 15min (169 miles). If you are staying overnight near the venue, leave your hotel instead and ignore the departure column.

Parent Manager Recommendation: An overnight stay avoids a pre-dawn Saturday drive. Two nights (Friday October 2 and Saturday October 3) is the pattern most traveling families use for this event.

6. Lodging

Official Tournament Information: our team plays at **Ballentine Park Complex**, so this list is ranked by distance to *that* complex only. Each of our teams can be at a different complex, so do not copy another team's hotel list. **5 of 5** hotels we verified fall inside our band (Primary 0–15 miles, Secondary 15–20 miles).

Inside the band — nearest first

WoodSpring Suites Columbia – Irmo • Choice

Distance: 4.4 mi / ~10 min to Ballentine Park Complex • Primary
Rate: \$219 per night • \$438 for two nights
Amenities: Extended-stay style, Free parking, Kitchenette
Checked: Distance verified 2026-09-26 in Google Maps

Hilton Garden Inn Columbia/Harbison • Hilton

Distance: 7.6 mi / ~15 min to Ballentine Park Complex • Primary
Rate: \$286 per night • \$572 for two nights
Amenities: Bonvoy-style full service, Restaurant on site, Pool
Checked: Distance verified 2026-09-26 in Google Maps

Hyatt Place Columbia/Harbison • Hyatt

Distance: 7.9 mi / ~16 min to Ballentine Park Complex • Primary
Rate: \$599 per night • two nights \$1,198 (rate spike on these dates)
Amenities: Suite-style seating, Free breakfast, Pool
Checked: Distance verified 2026-09-26 in Google Maps

MainStay Suites Columbia Harbison • Choice

Distance: 8.0 mi / ~16 min to Ballentine Park Complex • Primary
Rate: \$279 per night • last verified Sep 18 (no live rate returned Sep 26)
Amenities: All-suite, Kitchenette, Free parking
Checked: Distance verified 2026-09-26 in Google Maps

Tru by Hilton Harbison Columbia · Hilton

Distance:	8.2 mi / ~17 min to Ballentine Park Complex · Primary
Rate:	\$296 per night · \$592 for two nights
Amenities:	Bright lobby hangout, Free breakfast, Keeps Hilton points
Checked:	Distance verified 2026-09-26 in Google Maps

Distances are Google Maps driving distances from each hotel's verified street address to Ballentine Park Complex, checked on the dates shown. Rates are the nightly price we last verified live and are **not** re-dated here — confirm the current price before booking. Absence from this list does not mean a hotel is sold out.

7. Weather & Heat Planning

Live forecast, fetched September 26, 2026 from the National Weather Service for Irmo / Columbia. Friday October 2: mostly sunny, high **87°F**, 69°F overnight, with a slight chance of afternoon showers. Saturday October 3: high **84°F** with a chance of rain showers — our busiest day, every team plays twice. Sunday October 4 sits beyond the seven-day window, so plan on early-October normals and re-check in the last 48 hours.

Longer-range pattern — ten-year observed, not a forecast

Afternoon high	Around 80°F on average — has reached 95°F
Morning low	Around 63°F — noticeably cool at the first game
Rain	Roughly a 1-in-6 chance of measurable rain on any given day
Sun	Strong — open complexes with limited shade
Best games	Morning games are meaningfully cooler than afternoon

What this means for packing

This is a two-wardrobe weekend. Bring the heat gear — water, electrolytes, sunscreen, cooling towels — but also bring a jacket or warm layer for early mornings and a rain shell, because October in the Midlands is not August. Start hydrating the day before travel.

Forecast rows: live National Weather Service outlook for Irmo / Columbia, fetched September 26, 2026. Pattern rows: ten years of recorded daily observations for Columbia, SC (Open-Meteo historical archive, 2016–2025) — a climatology, not a prediction. Re-check the forecast in the last 48 hours before travel.

8. Venue, Parking & Fields

Official Tournament Information: Our team plays at **Ballentine Park Complex**, 1009 Bickley Road, Irmo, SC 29063. Below are all five SCUFC complexes in the area.

Ballentine Park Complex

1009 Bickley Road, Irmo, SC 29063
Listed as the tournament's primary venue on the event listing.

SCUFC West Soccer Complex

1053 Bird Road, Irmo, SC 29063

Polo Road Park

730 Polo Road, Columbia, SC 29229

Southeastern Freight Lines Soccer Center

115 Sunbelt Blvd, Columbia, SC 29203

SV Presbyterian Church Fields

125 Sparkleberry Lane, Columbia, SC 29229

Parking

Cost	Free — SCUFC complexes have on-site parking
Fill time	Fills early on tournament mornings
Fields	Grass; specific field layouts published per complex by SCUFC
Amenities	Concessions and restrooms at the complexes
Tent policy	Pending Confirmation — not published

Official field layouts (published by SCUFC):

- [Ballentine Park field layout](#)
- [SCUFC West field layout](#)
- [Polo Road Park field layout](#)
- [Southeastern Freight Lines field layout](#)

Parent Manager Recommendation: Arrive 30–45 minutes before your first game to secure parking and walk to your field. These are large, spread-out complexes.

9. Team Communication Plan

Official schedule	SincSports (Carolina Cup)
Team updates	PlayMetrics Messages • Email
Tournament logistics	Parent Manager

Soccer questions

Coach

Urgent changes

Team chat / text

An updated guide will be sent as soon as the schedule is released.

10. Coach Updates (Coming Soon)

This section will be updated once our coaches release arrival times, uniform details, and any team-specific instructions.

Parents do not need to act on these items — they are for reference once confirmed by the coaching staff.

11. Player Guidance

Tournament weekends are exciting and demanding for young players. A few practical reminders.

- Prioritize sleep — early bedtimes Friday and Saturday
- Keep meals familiar — not the weekend for new foods
- Bring simple, preferred snacks
- Encourage steady hydration throughout the day
- Limit exhausting hotel-pool activity before games
- Bring quiet activities for downtime between games
- Expect physical and emotional fatigue
- Keep postgame conversations positive and brief
- Let coaches handle the soccer instruction
- Emphasize effort, teamwork, learning, and fun

12. Packing Checklist

Player Gear

- ☐ Both uniform kits
- ☐ Cleats
- ☐ Shin guards
- ☐ Labeled water bottle
- ☐ Extra socks
- ☐ Warm-up / training gear
- ☐ Dry clothes
- ☐ Recovery shoes or sandals
- ☐ Personal medications
- ☐ Warm layer for early games

Weather & Hydration

- ☐ Water (plenty)
- ☐ Electrolytes
- ☐ Sunscreen (SPF 50+)
- ☐ Cooling towel
- ☐ Rain gear / shell
- ☐ Small fan
- ☐ Plastic bags for wet gear
- ☐ Extra blanket or jacket

Parent Sideline

- ☐ Folding chairs
- ☐ Wipes

- ☐ Umbrella
- ☐ Cooler
- ☐ Snacks
- ☐ Portable charger

- ☐ Trash bags
- ☐ Activities for siblings
- ☐ Cash for concessions
- ☐ Shade if permitted

Emergency

- ☐ Basic first-aid supplies
- ☐ Ice packs
- ☐ Insurance information
- ☐ Emergency contacts
- ☐ Prescriptions

13. Tournament Rules

Pending Confirmation

SCUFC has not published the 2026 Carolina Cup rules document. Game length, mercy rule, substitution rules, and the tiebreaker order are all still unconfirmed for this year. **We will not guess at these.** As soon as the rules are published we'll add the full breakdown — including the complete tiebreaker hierarchy — to this section and resend the guide.

What we do know

Format	7v7 for U8–U10 age groups
Age groups	U8–U19, boys and girls
Levels	Recreational, Intermediate, Advanced
Sanctioning	US Youth Soccer affiliated (SC Youth Soccer)
Check-in	Online only — no on-site check-in

Rules questions: Tournament Director Tripp Miller — tripp@scufc.com

Bracket questions (U8–U12): Jamie McClendon — jamie@scufc.com

14. Nearby Family Resources

Distances measured from Ballentine Park Complex — the one listing sites name as the primary venue, but **only one of the five possible complexes**. Information current as of September 18, 2026.

Closest to the venue

CVS Pharmacy	0.3 mi
Food Lion	0.4 mi
Walmart Supercenter	1.1 mi • 1180 Dutch Fork Road
Publix	2.3 mi • 2732 North Lake Drive

Forgot something?

Dick's Sporting Goods	6.2 mi • 1110 Bower Parkway
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Academy Sports + Outdoors	6.2 mi
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Near the Harbison hotel cluster

Trader Joe's	275 Harbison Boulevard
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Publix	150 Harbison Boulevard
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Rite Aid	5.1 mi from the venue
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15. Weekend Itinerary

Friday, October 2

Travel day for most families. Leave Savannah by early afternoon — about 3h 15min in free-flow conditions.

Saturday, October 3 — Group Play

10:30 AM EDT vs CESA U9B Pre ECNL-RL Summit 1 • Field 2A — arrive 9:45 AM

3:30 PM EDT vs CFA 17/18 Red • Field 2B — arrive 2:45 PM

Sunday, October 4 — Group Play

10:30 AM EDT vs SCUFC U9 Boys Blue • Field 2B — arrive 9:45 AM

Between-Games Rhythm

Saturday is a 10:30 AM and 3:30 PM double. The match runs about 65 minutes, so you have roughly 3 hours free in between at the same complex — enough to eat properly and cool down without leaving the area.

Final whistle ~11:35 AM

After game #703 on Field 2A.

Cool down + shade 11:35 AM

Ballentine has shade near the parking side. Change socks and shirts now, not later.

Real lunch, real sitting 12:00 PM

Eat within 30 minutes of the whistle while muscles are still warm — a proper meal, not snacks. Anywhere in Irmo/Ballentine; the Irmo cluster is 5-10 minutes away.

Quiet hour 1:00 PM

Shade, feet up, screens down. A 30-45 minute rest in the car with A/C does more for a 9-year-old than any drill.

Rehydrate + light warm-up 2:15 PM

Water and electrolytes sipped steadily from 1:00 PM — not a bottle all at once.

Back for game #706 2:45 PM

Field 2B. Parking is busiest about 30 minutes before kickoff.

16. Quick Reference

Screenshot this for game day.

Tournament	26th Annual Carolina Cup
Team	Savannah United 17/18B Premier
Dates	Oct 2–4, 2026
Venue	Complex not yet assigned • five SCUFC complexes
Venue confirmed	With the schedule on Sep 24
Drive	~169 mi • ~3h 15min
Hotel	Country Inn & Suites Harbison • \$161/nt
Format	U9 • 7v7
Check-in	Online only — opens after Sep 14
Weather	~66°F morning / ~85°F afternoon • layers + heat gear
Director	Tripp Miller • tripp@scufc.com
SCUFC	877-457-2832

17. Final Next Steps

- 1. Book your hotel now.** The Irmo area was 80% booked when we checked. A free-cancellation rate costs nothing to hold.
- 2. Watch for the accepted team list on September 14,** then complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in at this tournament.
- 3. Check the bracket September 16** and the **schedule September 26.** We'll send a refreshed guide with departure times once game times are live.
- 4. Pack for two climates** — cool mornings, warm afternoons, and a real chance of rain.
- 5. Check the forecast around September 28–30** for reliable day-by-day conditions.

Go, SU 17/18B Premier!

Looking forward to a great weekend in Columbia. Safe travels, and we'll send the updated guide as soon as the schedule drops.

